Real Women Have Curves

By Josefina Lopez

PLAYWRIGHT: **(Pg 6)** In the US undocumented people are referred to as "illegal aliens" . . . which conjures up the image of extraterrestrial beings who are not human, who do not bleed when they're cut, who do not cry when they feel pain, who do not have fears, dreams and hopes . . . Undocumented people have been (and still are) used as scapegoats for so many of the problems in the US, from drugs and violence to the economy. I hope that someday this country recognizes the very important contributions of undocumented people and remembers that they too came to this country in search of a better life.

INTRODUCTION

Join me today in the small garment shop of Estela Garcia and maybe you'll understand

Real Women Have Curves by Josefina Lopez.

*NOTE: Words in Spanish are in **bold** print. A glossary of Spanish terms appears at the end of this selection*

ANA: **(Pg 10)** *(to audience as she writes in her journal)* Monday, September 7 . . . I don't want to be here! I only come because my mother practically drags me out of bed and into the car and into the factory . . . Is it selfish of me not to want to wake up every morning at 6:30 am, Saturdays included, to come work here for 67 dollars a week? Oh, but such is the life of a Chicana in the garment industry. Cheap labor . . . I can't believe I've ended up here. I just graduated from high school. Most of my friends are in college. It's as if I'm going backwards. I'm doing the work that mostly illegal aliens do. No . . . "undocumented workers" . . . or else it sounds like these people come from Mars. Soon I will have my Temporary Residence Card. Then after two years, my green card. I'm happy to finally be legal, but I thought things would be different.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

CARMEN: *(pounding on the door)* Ana, open the door! Hurry! He's following me! *(Ana opens the door and Carmen hurries in nervously.)* **(Pg 14)** I saw a van! **La migra!** *(Ana quickly shuts the door and they hide, waiting to be discovered . . . after a few seconds)*

PANCHA: **Pero**, why are we hiding? **(Pg 15)** Let those men in their van come! We're all legal now! *(the women begin their work shift, sewing, ironing. They talk as they work)*

ESTELA: I'm not.

ANA: But you went with me to get the fingerprints and the medical examination.

ESTELA: I didn't send them in. *(Beat)* I have a criminal record.

CARMEN: **(Pg 16)** Estela, what did you do?

ESTELA: I was arrested for illegal possession of . . .

PANCHA: A gun?!

ESTELA: A lobster . . . out of season! I almost got handcuffed and taken to jail. Trying to "abduct" a lobster is taken very seriously in Santa Monica. **And** I'm being sued for not keeping up with my payments on the machines. I thought I could make the monthly payments if everything went as planned.

CARMEN: **Pos que paso?**

ESTELA: **(Pg 17)** We never finish on time, so the Glitz company doesn't pay until we do. We get behind, they don't pay, and I can't pay those pigs that sold me those machines. They're taking me to court. . . And if I appear in court, they'll find out that I don't have any papers.

ANA: **(Pg 22)** How much do they pay us for making these dresses? *(she holds one up)*

ROSALI: Estela, we get thirteen dollars for these, no?

ANA: How much do they sell them for at the stores?

ESTELA: They sell them at Bloomingdale's for about two hundred dollars.

ANA: Dang!

ESTELA: **(Pg 32)** Let's get to work. **A trabajar**! *(She turns on the radio)*

RADIO (VOICE OVER): **(Pg 33-34)** For those who just joined us today we are discussing abusive spouses. We have our last caller on the line.

CALLER: I want to know how I can talk to my husband when he gets angry.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

RADIO (VOICE OVER): How long has he been abusive?

CALLER: He tells me if I did whatever he asked he wouldn't have to hit me. But I do what he says and it's still not good enough. Last time he hit me because . . .

CARMEN: **Pobre mujer**, I'm lucky **mi viejo** doesn't hit me.

ANA: Lucky? That woman should leave her husband.

PANCHA: You think it's that easy?

ANA: No, she's probably dependent on him financially, or the church tells her to endure, or she's doing it for the children. But we can't allow ourselves to be abused anymore. We have to realize that we have rights! We have the right to control our bodies. No more!

CARMEN: **(Pg 57)** When your **Apa** would leave me in Mexico to go to **el norte**, he would leave me pregnant so no man would look at me and desire me. I was always scared of him. And I let myself get fat after you were born hoping he would be disgusted by me and not touch me anymore.

ANA: Why didn't you just say "No."?

CARMEN: Because, **M'ija**, I was never taught how to say no. *(beat, change of subject)* **(Pg 12)** give me your secret, Rosali. Maybe this way I can lose this ball of fat! *(She squeezes her stomach)* You can't even see my waist anymore. *(Ana laughs)* Why do you laugh? You're getting there yourself. When I was your age, I wasn't as fat as you. And look at your **chichis**! They must wight five pounds each! **(Pg 58)** Why don't you lose weight? Young girls should try to make themselves as attractive as possible.

ANA: Why? You're overweight too.

CARMEN: But I'm already married.

ANA: Is that it? Make myself attractive so I can catch a man?

ESTELA: *(sarcastically)* Ana, listen to them, learn now, "or you'll end up like Estela." **(Pg 59)** I want to be taken seriously, to be considered a person. With Andres, on our date . . . I got all fixed up. *(twirls)* He said, "I don't care if you're fat. I like you even better; more to grab." That got me so angry! I though he was interested in me because he was impressed

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

that I owned this factory. That "I'm smart" . . . When am I going to meet that man who will see the real me?

ROSALI: I've felt fat ever since I can remember.

ESTELA: Rosali, you're not fat.

ROSALI: Of course, I am. Look at my **nalgas** . . .and my hips! I look like a cow.

RADIO (VOICE OVER): **(Pg 41)** The time now is 2:35 pm. Twenty illegal aliens were captured today at the Goodnight Pillow Factory.

PANCHA: That's only a few blocks away!

RADIO (VOICE OVER): The owner was fined up to 2,000 dollars per alien . . .

CARMEN: Estela, call the Glitz company and ask them, no, demand that they pay you for the last order of dresses. Even if they were late, they still have to pay us.

ESTELA: I don't want to be too pushy. They're the only company that has been willing to give us a contract.

CARMEN: Then do it for Pancha and Rosali. You haven't paid them and **las pobrecitas** can't even buy groceries.

ESTELLA: *(She thinks about it, then decides to be brave and do it)* **(Pg 42)** Hello, this is Estela Garcia . . . No, but we're almost finished. I know . . . I know. . . I've got a lawyer working on that . . . I'll get it to you by next week . . . Okay, Mrs. Glitz . . . I'm sorry. *(she hangs up, her face expresses worry and fear)*

CARMEN: Que te dijo la vieja?

ESTELA: She asked about my proof of employment papers again. She warned me that if **la migra** shuts us down, she won't pay us for **all** the work we've done. I'm going to get deported. I'll lose everything I've worked for, the factory . . . my self-respect.

PANCHA: **(Pg 56)** How many more dresses to finish, Estela?

ESTELA: Fifteen *(counting dresses on the rack)* 184, 185, 186. We only need 14.

CARMEN: **(Pg 61)** *(and suddenly Carmen has a idea)* Estela, I've been thinking . . You know what we could do? We could copy the patterns for these dresses and make the dresses for ourselves.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

ROSALI: Jaime could sell them in the flea market!

ANA: That's a great idea! Why don't we make them in larger sizes too?

PANCHA: We could probably sell more if we made them in larger sizes.

ESTELA: And from there, if we make more money than what we're making now, maybe we can rent a place downtown and start a boutique!

PANCHA: You could go to school and study fashion design and design our dresses!

ESTELA: I **could** do that . . . *(She grins)* **(Pg 64)** Large sizes?! *(she picks up a measuring tape and begins taking her own measurements)*

SPOKEN TRANSITION - The women head home for the day, but not Estela – She works through the night – and the next day . . .

ESTELLA: **(Pg 67-68)** *(with new-found determination she dials the phone)* Mrs. Glitz? This is Estela Garcia. I wanted to tell you that you are a mean, wicked, unsympathetic, greedy, rude. . . Capitalist! We quit . . .

CARMEN: What have you done?

PANCHA: You got us fired, didn't you?

ESTELA: No, we quit! *(Estela laughs)* Don't worry. I got us a contract with Senor Vasquez!

ANA: **(Pg 69)** *(steps out of scene to speak to audience)* As for me . . . I wrote an essay on my experience and was awarded a fellowship to New York University! *(beat)* I always took their work for granted. I was going to be better than them. I wanted to show them how much smarter and liberated I was. But in their subtle ways, they taught me about resistance. About a battle no one was fighting for them except themselves. About the loneliness of being women in a country that looks down on us for being mothers and submissive wives. With their work that seems simple and unimportant, they are fighting… Perhaps the greatest thing I learned from them is that women are powerful, especially when working together. [When I came back from school] plans for making the boutique were no longer a dream, but a reality. *(She picks up a jacket and puts it on)* Now I wear original designs from Estela Garcia's boutique, "Real Women Have Curves."

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Josefina Lopez
ISBN: 978-0871297259
Publisher: Dramatic Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Dec 1995

AWARD HISTORY

2014 National Qualifier

Glossary / Spanish

A trabajar – To work it is
Ama – mama
Apa – papa
Chichis – boobs
El norte – The North
La migra – US Immigration and Naturalization Service officials
Las pobrecitas – the poor women
Mi Viejo – my husband
M'ija – my daughter
Nalgas – buttocks
Pero – but
Pobre mujer – poor woman
Pos que paso? – Well, what happened?
Que te dijo la vieja? – What did the old hag tell you?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY